

Canva Workflow

Polish AI Images for Instagram Without Overdesign

AI Virtual Influencer Starter Kit

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Canva is the finishing step — not the place to reinvent the character. The photo should lead; text supports.

Pipeline position: Quality-approved AI image → Canva → export → Instagram

Step 1 — Brand Kit Setup (once)

In Canva (Brand Kit if Pro, or a dedicated “Brand” folder if free):

1. Upload logo or wordmark (optional)
2. Save **3–5 brand colors**
3. Pick **1 heading font + 1 body font**
4. Save profile photo and highlight cover styles
5. Create a folder: AI Influencer / [Name]

See also Design-System-Checklist.md.

Step 2 — Import

1. Upload only **quality-gate approved** images
2. Name files before upload: YYYY-MM-DD_pillar_format.jpg
3. Do not import 50 rejects — decision fatigue kills batching

Step 3 — Choose Size

Open a design with the correct Instagram size from Instagram-Size-Specs .md.

Content	Start with
Single feed photo	1080×1350 (4:5)
Carousel slide	1080×1350
Reel cover	1080×1920
Story	1080×1920
Profile / highlight	per specs doc

Step 4 — Place the Image

1. Fill the frame; avoid large empty letterboxing
2. Keep the face in the upper two-thirds when possible
3. Leave **safe margin** for UI (especially Stories/Reels)
4. Crop out bad hands or weird edges instead of “fixing” with stickers

Step 5 — Text Overlays (optional)

Use text only when the format needs it (tips, quotes, covers).

Rules

- Max 1 main line + 1 support line on photos
- Never cover the eyes or mouth
- High contrast (light text on dark scrim if needed)
- Same fonts every week
- Avoid fake “Instagram UI” clutter

When to skip text entirely: strong portrait + good caption is enough.

Step 6 — Carousels

1. Duplicate page for each slide
2. Slide 1 = hook / title
3. Middle slides = one idea each
4. Final slide = CTA (save / comment / follow)
5. Keep margins and title position locked across slides

Use layout brief: `Canva-Template-Brief.md` → Carousel.

Step 7 — Export

Destination	Setting
Feed / carousel	PNG or high-quality JPG
Stories / Reels covers	PNG
Transparency needed	PNG

- ☐ Filename matches calendar day
- ☐ Moved to 04 - ready folder
- ☐ Paired caption stored in same note or sheet

Step 8 — Do Not Overdo

Skip unless brand-critical:

- Heavy filters that change skin tone
- Random stickers and sparkles
- Watermarks on every post (optional light mark max)
- Borders that fight the photo
- Too many fonts

20-Minute Canva Sprint

Min	Action
0–3	Open correct size
3–8	Drop image + crop
8–14	Add text if needed
14–17	Check margins / face
17–20	Export + file rename

Repeat per post. Batch the same template across the week.